

Moroccan tagine with chickpeas, olives, and prunes

A tagine, a stew named for the conical earthenware vessel it is traditionally cooked in, is a **richly flavored** dish loaded with herbs, spices, and perfectly cooked vegetables. In traditional Moroccan restaurants, the stew is slowly simmered on the bottom of a couscousier while the couscous steams above. To simplify, I bake this stew with excellent results. Dried or canned beans work equally well in this dish, but given all the other ingredients and prep work involved, I recommend **canned beans to make your life easier.**

4 shallots, coarsely chopped
1 celery rib, chopped
1 inch of fresh ginger, peeled and slivered [2.5cm]
2 garlic cloves, slivered
1 cinnamon stick
2 tablespoons olive oil
2 teaspoons paprika
2 teaspoons ground cumin
2 teaspoons ground coriander
1 teaspoon salt
1 teaspoon freshly ground black pepper
¼ teaspoon cayenne pepper
1 can (32 ounces) crushed tomatoes [1 L]

1 can (15 ounces) cooked chickpeas [425g]
1 small butternut squash or sweet potato, peeled and cut into bite-size chunks
1 large carrot, peeled and cut into small bite-size chunks
½ fennel bulb, cut into 1-inch [2.5-cm] pieces
½ to 1 cup vegetable stock or water [125 to 250ml]
½ teaspoon saffron threads, crushed
½ head of cauliflower, cut into bite-size florets
6 ounces green beans, steamed until tender [180g]
3 ounces pitted kalamata olives [90g]
4 ounces pitted prunes, cut in half [120g]
3 tablespoons coarsely chopped parsley

1. **Preheat** the oven to 350°F [175°C]. In a large flameproof casserole, cook the shallots, celery, ginger, garlic, and cinnamon stick in the olive oil over medium-low heat for 5 to 7 minutes, stirring often, until the vegetables are softened but not browned.
2. Add the paprika, cumin, coriander, salt, black pepper, and cayenne. **Cook**, stirring, for about 1 minute, until the spices are nicely fragrant. Stir in the crushed tomatoes, then add the chickpeas, squash, carrots, and fennel. Pour in just enough vegetable stock to cover. Mix well and add the saffron. Cover and bring to a boil.
3. Transfer to the oven and **bake** for 20 minutes. Add the cauliflower and return to the oven for 10 to 20 minutes, or until the vegetables are just tender.
4. About 5 minutes before the tagine is done, stir in the green beans, olives, and prunes. **Garnish** with the parsley and serve hot over couscous.

SERVES 6 TO 8

